What a Study Can Prove

Name _____

Two questions decide what a study can tell us.

1. Was the sample chosen at **random** from the population?
2. Were the treatments given by **random assignment**?

If yes, we can **generalize** to the population.

If yes, and the difference is too big to be just chance, we can say the treatment **caused** the result.

	Random assignment	**No random assignment**
Random sample	Cause: yes Generalize: yes	Cause: no Generalize: yes
Not a random sample	Cause: yes, for these subjects Generalize: no	Cause: no Generalize: no

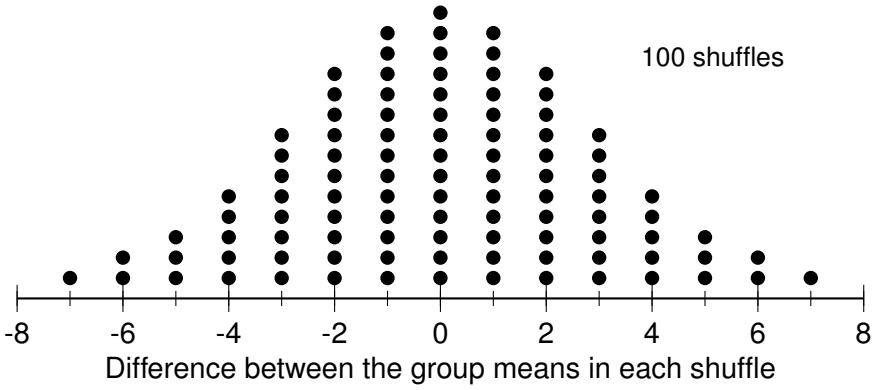
Sample surveys and **observational studies** have no random assignment. They can show an **association**, but not a cause.

Is the difference real, or just chance?

20 students were randomly split into two groups of 10. One group took a 5-minute stretch break before a quiz. The break group scored **6 points higher** on average.

Even if the break does nothing, two random groups will score a little differently. To see how big a difference chance can make, we **simulate**:

1. Shuffle the 20 scores into two random groups of 10.
2. Find the difference between the group means.
3. Repeat 100 times.



Only **3** of the 100 shuffles gave a difference of 6 or more. A 6-point difference is very unlikely to happen by chance alone. We say the result is **statistically significant**. The break probably helped.

The 5% rule: if chance gives a result this big less than about 5% of the time, call it statistically significant.

Work with a partner. Compare answers when you finish each problem.

1. For each study, can we conclude cause? Can we generalize to the population? Explain.

   (a) Researchers randomly choose 1,000 adults in Missouri and ask how much they exercise and how often they get sick.

   (b) 40 volunteers are randomly assigned to drink green tea or water every day for a month. The tea group has much lower blood pressure. The difference is too big to be just chance.

   (c) A teacher compares the grades of students who chose to join a study club with students who did not.

2. Use the simulation dot plot on page 1. Each dot is the difference between two random groups when the treatment does nothing.

   (a) Suppose the break group had scored only 2 points higher. How many of the 100 shuffles gave a difference of 2 or more?

   (b) Is a 2-point difference statistically significant? Explain.

3. Find the mistake in each conclusion.

   (a) A study followed 500 randomly chosen adults for 20 years. The coffee drinkers lived longer. Conclusion: “Coffee makes you live longer.”

   (b) 30 runners from one gym were randomly assigned to two training plans. Plan A runners got much faster than Plan B runners. Conclusion: “Plan A will make every runner in the country faster.”

   (c) In a randomized experiment, Group A scored 1 point higher than Group B. A simulation shows chance gives a difference of 1 or more about 40% of the time. Conclusion: “Treatment A works better.”

4. A headline says: “Students who eat dinner with their family get better grades.” The data came from a survey. Rewrite the headline so it does not claim a cause.